

offers scholars and students to delve into Tibb (Unani medicine), *tazkira* (biographies), *tasawwuf* (Islamic mysticism), comparative religions and literature on the Freedom Movement and national integration.

The Rampur Raza Library, on the other hand, houses over 500 rare manuscripts. These include the Koran, *Jami'-ul-Tawarikh*; *Shah-Nama* of Firdausi and *Kalila-wa-Dimna*, the Persian translation of the

Bhagvad Gita and *Valamiki Ramayana* in the Persian Nasta'liq script. It was authored by Sumer Chand in 1713.

The library has 15,000 such artistic manuscripts—of which 150 are illustrated with 4,413 pictures—and 205 handwritten palm leaves, 1,000 miniature paintings and 3,000 specimens of Islamic calligraphy. The subjects are varied: history, philosophy, religions, sciences, art, litera-

Firdausi with 52 paintings from A.D. 1430, and 157 paintings prepared by Akbar's painters at Fatehpur Sikri.

The Government has awarded the library's efforts for preserving three manuscripts in their original form—Hazrat Ali's Koran, Chand's *Ramayana* and *Kalila-wa-Dimna*. To protect these priceless manuscripts, the Centre has deployed the Central Industrial Security Force at the library at a cost of Rs 1 crore a year;



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THE LIBRARY HAS BECOME A CENTRE OF RESEARCH FOR SCHOLARS OF ISLAMIC STUDIES AND MEDIEVAL INDIAN HISTORY WITH ITS COLLECTION OF LITERATURE.

IMTIAZ AHMAD, director, Khuda Baksh Library

(CLOCKWISE FROM LEFT) THE RAMPUR RAZA LIBRARY; AN ILLUSTRATION FROM THE *DIWAN-I-HAFIZ*; THE *RAMAYANA* IN PERSIAN; MANUSCRIPTS AT THE KHUDA BAKSH LIBRARY; A KORAN INLAID WITH GOLD

Panch Tantra, a collection of Indian fables. Written in the Nasta'liq script, it has been selected as one of the Indian Heritage Manuscripts by the Ministry of Culture. The *Panch Tantra* was originally written in Sanskrit; it was later translated into Persian and then into Arabic. The library also preserves 13 handwritten volumes of the

ture, medicine, astronomy, astrology, mathematics, geology and fine arts. There is also an ancient Koran whose verses are underlined with gold and decorated with colour ground by stones, flowers and leaves. Even centuries after it was written, its colours are still as bright as new. The miniature paintings represent the Turko-Mongol, Mughal, Persian, Rajput, Pahari, Awadhi and Indo-European schools of art, which are of great value for researchers. Among important illustrated manuscripts is the *Diwan-i-Hafiz*, which was scribed during Akbar's reign in A.D. 1570-80. The library also has the *Shah Nama*

Rs 55 lakh is spent annually on the security of Khuda Bakhsh Library. The Raza Library has another masterpiece, a Koran whose every sentence starts with the Arabic alphabet Alif (equivalent to the Roman alphabet A), hence called the *Alafi Koran*.

Both libraries are rich in medieval scientific instruments, artifacts and astronomical instruments. The Khuda Baksh Library has astrolabes and sun dials, a celestial globe, a quadrant-cum-nocturnal instrument called in Roznuma-o-Shabnuma and surgical forceps. Significantly, Patna was well-known for making sun dials in the 19th century. Ahmad says, "These are undoubtedly an important source for the study and reconstruction of science and technology in the pre-modern period." They also provide insight into the development astronomy, surgery and geography in pre-modern India. Truly a treasure trove from medieval India. ■